

Saga (1892), commissioned by the conductor Robert Kajanus (see [box](#)). He also produced the first of many unaccompanied choral works, *Rakastava* (The Lover), a beautifully imagined small masterpiece. In 1893, his *Karelia*—incidental music written for a pageant in the town of Viipuri (now Vyborg)—celebrated the culture of the northeastern province of Finland (now part of Russia).

The composer's next major statement was a symphonic suite that was based on the exploits of Lemminkäinen, the adventurer-warrior of the *Kalevala*. The premiere in 1896 was a lukewarm success, but one of the movements, "The Swan of Tuonela," soon took on an independent life of its own; the music's long cor anglais solo, uncoiling against a background of muted and divided strings, is one of Sibelius's great feats of imagination.

His First Symphony, strongly influenced by Tchaikovsky, premiered in 1899 and was followed by the far more individual Second Symphony, with its masterly first movement that stitches together fragmentary themes into a central development section, and then unpicks them again.

Meanwhile, the waves of Finnish nationalism were rolling high. In 1899, a Russian-imposed "February Manifesto" abolished Finnish freedom of speech and right of assembly. A pageant was organized in Helsinki to protest at the suppression of press freedom, and Sibelius composed a six-movement orchestral sequence for the occasion; the last item, *Finland Awakes*, later revised and renamed *Finlandia*, secured his international fame.